

Edward Barnes; helped shape modernism in architecture

By Robert Campbell
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Edward Larrabee Barnes, one of the leading American architects of his generation, died Tuesday of complications from a stroke suffered in April. He was 89.

He and his wife Mary had made their home in Harvard Square since 1995, after he retired from his New York office.

As an architect, Mr. Barnes was known as a modernist who stuck to the modernist creed, ignoring changing fashions as he crafted a personal style of his own. He studied architecture at Harvard University, where he was one of a remarkable generation of young designers attracted to that school in the 1940s by Walter Gropius, the former director of the Bauhaus School in Germany. Gropius's students, including Philip Johnson, IM Pei, and Paul Rudolph, led the nation into modernism in the decades after World War II.

Mr. Barnes's early work was notable for crisply geometrical buildings, often of richly textured wood or shingle. The best known is the Haystack Mountain School of Crafts on Deer Isle, Maine, built in 1961, an informal cluster of shed-roofed pavilions and dock-like pathways that seems to float above the forest site as it spills down a hillside toward the ocean. Haystack had a strong influence on other architects who, like Mr. Barnes, were seeking a humane version of modernism. In 1994, it won the prestigious Twenty-Five Year Award from the American Institute of Architects, a prize awarded annually to an American building that has stood the test of time.

Among his many later buildings are the IBM Corporate Headquarters tower on Madison Avenue in New York, with its generous public greenhouse filled with clumps of bamboo; the Walker Art Center in Minneapolis, often cited by curators as among the best museums in the nation; the Dallas Museum of Art; a master plan for the State University of New York at Purchase; and the Thurgood Marshall Federal Judiciary Building in Washington.

Mr. Barnes was born in Chicago in 1915. His father was a lawyer and Harvard graduate and his mother, Margaret Ayer Barnes, was a writer who won the 1931 Pulitzer Prize for her novel "Years of Grace." Mr. Barnes attended Milton Academy and Harvard, where he was president of the Glee Club and a varsity wrestler. He started Harvard as an English major, but later switched to architectural history. After college, he briefly taught English and other subjects at Milton Academy.

He was inspired to become an architect after a visit to two houses in Lincoln, which Gropius and his colleague Marcel Breuer had built for themselves. Mr. Barnes returned to Harvard and received



1969 AP FILE PHOTO

Edward Larrabee Barnes, flanked by Jacqueline Onassis and Rose Kennedy, attending a Broadway production.

his master of architecture degree in 1942.

After serving during World War II in the Naval Reserve in San Francisco, he worked in California for designer Henry Dreyfus on the development of low-cost, prefabricated housing. "At that time there was no question in my mind that modern architecture and social commitment were inextricably linked," he once said.

He found little government support for affordable housing and moved to New York where he started his own practice in 1949. His wife Mary, who studied architecture in London, was among his collaborators and also served as curator of architecture at the Museum of Modern Art from 1947 to 1949.

Mr. Barnes was a tall, lanky, soft-spoken man who dressed in preppie tweeds and seersuckers. Until late in life, he spent an hour each morning running outdoors. He did most of his designing on weekends in his house in Mt. Kisco, N.Y., where he had a studio, and he would go to the New York office on Monday mornings with carefully worked out drawings for his staff. He was a person of warmth and charm, and in spite of his success, of great modesty.

He liked his buildings to be as simple and logical as his clothes. They do not attempt to be flamboyantly original works of art. They are, rather, places that fit their sites, their inhabitants, and their purposes. They often have a spare and understated simplicity.

Mr. Barnes's buildings in New England, besides Haystack, include the 28 State Street office tower in Boston (formerly New England Merchants Bank); the Cathedral of the Immaculate Conception in Burlington, Vt.; Old Stone Square office building in Providence; dormitories at the



GLOBE STAFF FILE PHOTO

Mr. Barnes designed the sleek 28 State Street tower in Boston.

Harvard Divinity School, St. Paul's School, Deerfield Academy, and Bennington and Middlebury colleges; and a number of private houses. A book on his work, "Edward Larrabee Barnes: Architect," published in 1994, lists 123 works.

Mr. Barnes won numerous awards. He received the Thomas Jefferson Medal from the University of Virginia in 1981 and a 350th Anniversary Medal from Harvard in 1986. He was a fellow

of the American Academy of Arts and Sciences and of the American Academy of Arts and Letters. In 1980, his firm received the Firm Award from the American Institute of Architects.

He leaves his wife Mary; a son, John, an architect who is director of campus planning at the University of California-Santa Cruz; and two granddaughters. A private memorial service will be held in Cambridge at a later date.

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